

2c. Content of unit group 1: British period study and enquiry (Units Y101 to Y113)

Introduction to unit group 1

Centres should choose one unit from the thirteen available in unit group 1.

Each unit has two elements: a Period Study and an Enquiry. The Enquiry element either precedes or continues the Period Study element so as to provide increased coherence and coverage of the chosen period of British history.

The Period Study element of the unit is assessed by essays, which will allow learners to develop their use and understanding of historical terms, concepts and skills. The length of the periods studied will encourage learners to develop their interest in, and understanding of, important developments. The topics available in the units in this group will enable learners to ask significant questions about important issues. They are sufficiently broad and balanced to ensure both coherence and variety and have sufficient chronological range to provide for the study of continuity and change, which allows analysis of causes and consequences within the periods.

The addition of the Enquiry element to either the beginning or end of the period will ensure that learners do not have a borehole approach to their study, but will be able to see change and developments, and make substantiated judgements, over a substantial length of time, so that they can see issues in a wider perspective. The Enquiry topic areas include the study of significant individuals, societies, events and issues. They also include a range of different historical perspectives, for example aesthetic, cultural, economic, ethnic, political, religious, scientific, social and technological.

The nature of the examination will require learners to demonstrate an understanding of the key historical terms and concepts relevant to the period studied. The questions relating to the Period Study element will require learners to recall, select and deploy

appropriate knowledge and communicate this clearly and effectively. Learners will be expected to demonstrate abilities to explain, assess, analyse and consider the relationships between key features of the period studied in order to reach substantiated judgements. All responses will require judgements, and at the top level will be more analytical with judgements more effectively substantiated than similar questions set at AS Level. This is ensured by a more demanding top level to the generic mark scheme.

In the Enquiry element, the focus will be on the critical use of evidence in investigating and assessing historical questions, problems and issues. The link with the Period Study will make it easier for teachers to provide the historical background, context and awareness of how their option is located within the longer term developments of the topic. The focus of the questions may be on depth of one Key topic or breadth, using parts of several key topics for the evaluation of a theme. Each Enquiry topic is of sufficient length to provide a coherent and worthwhile study within the overall period. Each provides a range of perspectives affecting individuals, societies and groups and will enable learners to analyse and evaluate different interpretations and representations of the past through contemporary perspectives. The critical evaluation of sources will be central to this element, with all marks awarded against AO2. The sources selected for examination will be a range of types of written sources, contemporary to the period. Learners will always have to analyse and evaluate **four** sources, answering **one** question which sets the sources in their historical context. The complexity of this task thus represents differentiation from AS, where fewer sources are analysed and shorter-answer questions are set. Sources will be fully attributed and only edited for accessibility. Learners' knowledge of the historical context will only be credited insofar as it is used to analyse and evaluate the sources in relation to the question set.

Enquiry Topic: Alfred the Great	
Key Topics	Content Learners should have studied the following:
Alfred and the Vikings	Alfred's position in 871; the defence of Wessex; the threat of the Great Heathen Army (865–878), Alfred's refuge at Athelney and defeat of the Great Heathen Army, terms of peace, the capture of London (886); reorganisation of the army and navy; reasons for and extent of military success (leadership, strategy, tactics, resources-reorganisation of the army and navy, logistics, chance); return of the Vikings in the 890s.
Alfred and the governance of England	Administrative reforms and establishment of unity in Alfred's territory; the creation of <i>burhs</i> (origins, functions, growth, consequences); the <i>Burghal Hidage</i> , examples of <i>burhs</i> including Winchester, Oxford, Chichester and Wareham; the links between <i>burhs</i> and local economies; Alfred's law code; England at the time of Alfred's death; Alfred as 'King of the English'.
The revival of literacy and learning: the Alfredian Renaissance	Court intellectuals and the programme for learning; the connection between learning, religion and defeat of the Vikings; the role of writings and translations (including Bede's Ecclesiastical History); the role of Asser; Latin education for priests; the use of literature as propaganda.

Key Topics	Content Learners should have studied the following:
Edward the Elder 899–924	The avoidance of dynastic feuds; the challenge of Scandinavian settlement and migration from Denmark; the campaigns of Edward and Aethelflaed (the ‘conquest of the Danelaw’); the ‘submission’ of the Welsh kings (918), the Scottish king (923) and Raegnald (920); the threat of the Norwegians from Ireland (including Raegnald); the extent of Edward’s power in 924.
Athelstan 924–939	The capture of York 927; relations with Scotland (including the battle of Brunanburh, 937); continued problems with the Vikings; connections with the Continent (including Flanders, France, Germany and Norway); government and administration (role of magnates and ealdorman; changes in the nature of the court and royal council); Athelstan’s legal codes (II and VI).
Edmund 939–946, Eadred 946–955 and Edgar 957–975	The return of the Vikings (including Olaf Guthfrithson as King of York); the recovery of the northern Danelaw; the taking of Strathclyde; Edmund as liberator of the Danes; Eadred’s struggles with Eric Bloodaxe and Olaf Sihtricson and Eadred’s invasion of Northumbria; Edgar’s reforms: legal codes, charters, the role of the Witan, improvements in local government and administration, coinage; Edgar’s patronage of new monasteries and monastic reform, developments in Church art and architecture; Edgar’s coronation as King of all England 973.
Aethelred 978–1016	The crisis over the new monasticism; the murder of Edward the Martyr (978); the return of the Vikings: the influence of Danish royalty, the treaty of 991 with Richard, Duke of Normandy, the battle of Maldon, tribute, divisions within the English nobility, the role of Viking leaders (including Sweyn, Thorkell and Cnut); the legislation of Aethelred (including the ‘10’ legal codes, monetary law, the role of the ‘jury’); cultural developments (including the Church and education, the roles of Wulfstan and Aelfric, Aethelweard’s translation of the Chronicle).